

# Class 2: Causes, Radicalisation, Mobilisation

Causes: Setting the stage for political violence

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

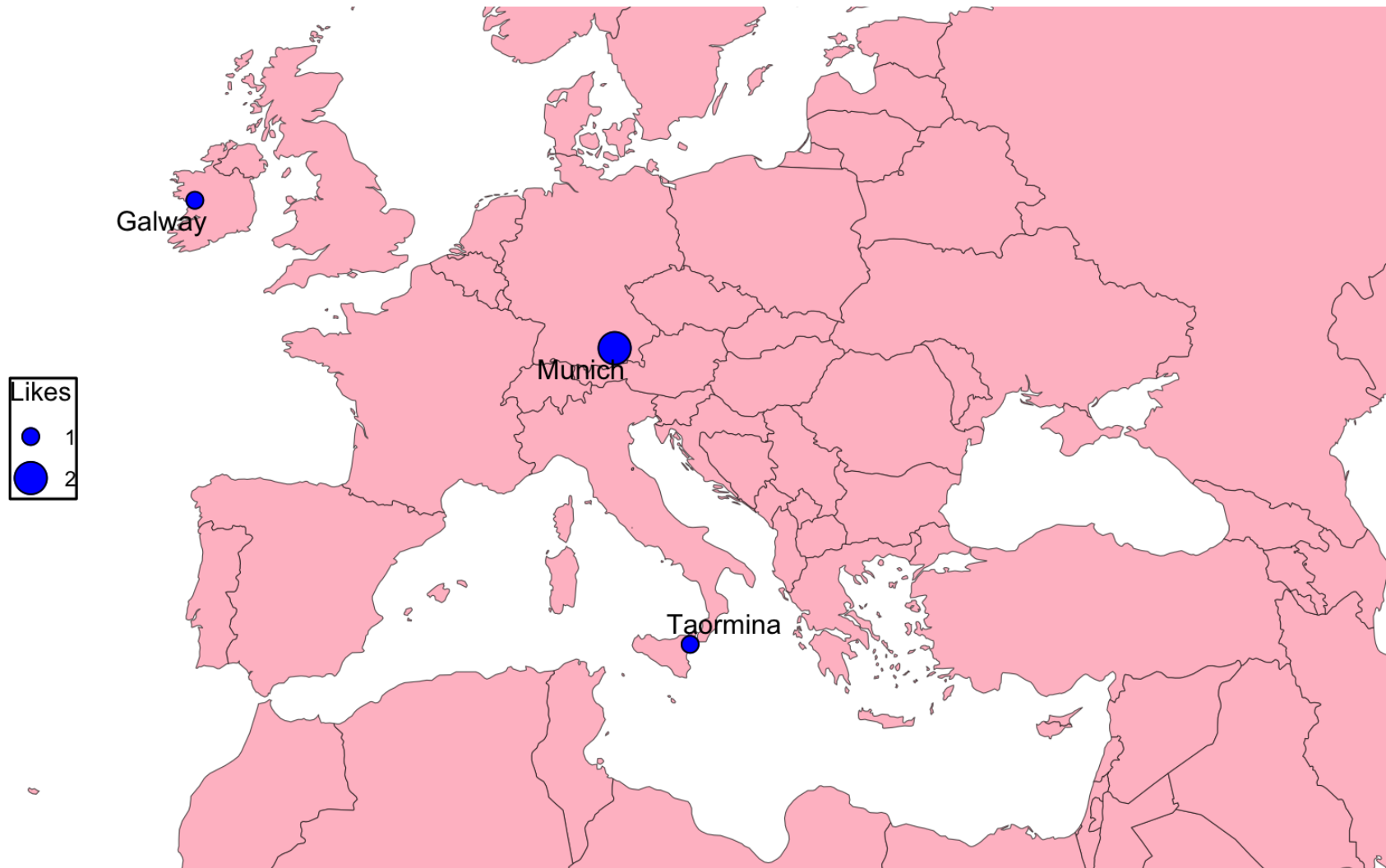
# Agenda for the day

- Opening notes
- A causal framework of political violence
- Politically violent groups connected to Germany
- Open data - Global Terrorism Database
- Other PV groups that will crop up in readings
- Assigning groups for in-depth study
- Testing: determinants of right-wing terrorism in the U.S.
- Any feedback for this class?

# Opening notes



# Students' favourite cities



# Presentation groups

Remember: topic to me at least by Week 4

December

January

## Presentations line-up

| Date    | Presenters | Method |
|---------|------------|--------|
| 4 Dec:  |            | TBD    |
| 11 Dec: |            | TBD    |
| 18 Dec: |            | TBD    |

# A causal framework of political violence

# Three organising questions (Crenshaw 1981)

- Terrorist violence communicates a political message; its ends go beyond damaging an enemy's material resources

## 1. **why** does terrorism occur?

- *predictive/causal* questions

## 2. **how** do the processes of terrorism work?

- *processual/mechanistic* questions

## 3. **what** are its social and political **effects**?

- *descriptive* and *causal* questions

# Common problems (Crenshaw 1981)

(still applicable to significant portions of political violence and research several decades on...)

- logical comparability
- specification of the relationship of variables to each other
- rank-ordering of variables in terms of explanatory power

# 3 levels of causation (Crenshaw 1981)

1. broad environment/contextual factors (**macro-level**)
  2. circumstances and actors (**meso-level**)
  3. psychological variables that encourage or inhibit (**micro-level**)
- these *levels* are a useful and widely applicable analytical framework

# Context (macro-level): preconditions

## Any ideas what is depicted here?



# Context (macro-level): preconditions

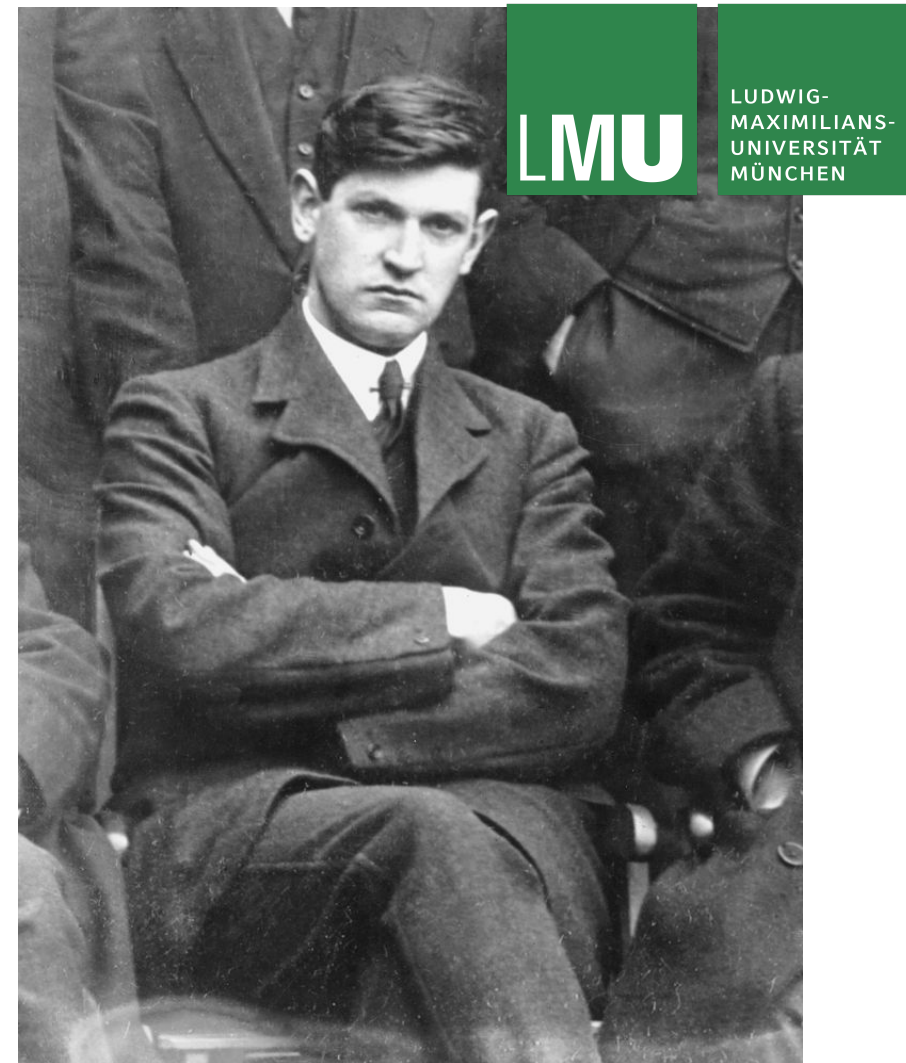
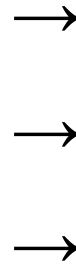
# Context (macro-level): precipitants

- **precipitants**, specific events that immediately precede the occurrence of terrorism

a common pattern of government actions that act as catalysts for terrorism. Government use of unexpected and unusual force in response to protestor reform attempts often compels terrorist retaliation. (p384)

Examples?

# Context (macro-level): precipitants



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- **precipitants**, specific events that immediately precede the occurrence of terrorism

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Examples?

# Circumstances (meso-level) (Crenshaw 1981)

- terrorist behaviour as “rational”
  - based on assumption that terrorist organisations have consistent sets of values, beliefs, and images of the environment. Hence, terrorism is seen collectively as a logical means
- variety of **goals**
  - from revolutionary - e.g., new state, new system
  - to (essentially) conservative - e.g., preserve social group relations, power arrangements

# Circumstances (meso-level): variety of goals (1981)

- can serve long-term **strategy** and/or proximate objectives
- gain attention, win support
- disrupt/discredit government/state
- provoke reactions:
  - affects public attitudes positively and negatively, creating either sympathy in a potential constituency or fear and hostility in an audience identified as the “enemy.”
  - government counteraction
- internal organisation functions: control, discipline, morale-building
- actors’ impatience

# Circumstances (meso-level) (Crenshaw 1981)

The observation that terrorism is a **weapon of the weak** is hackneyed but apt. (p387)

## What does this mean? Do you agree?

- inexpensive, simple
- contrast: James C. Scott's book (1985), *Weapons of the Weak: Everyday Forms of Peasant Resistance*

# Psychological (micro-level): common traits (Crenshaw)

two fundamental questions about the psychological basis of terrorism:

1. why the individual takes the first step and chooses to engage in terrorism: why join? Does the terrorist possess specific psychological predispositions, identifiable in advance, that suit them for terrorism?
  - radicalisation and engagement
2. Why does involvement continue? What are the psychological mechanisms of group interaction?
  - persistence or endurance

# Psychological (micro-level): common traits (Crenshaw)

- ego-defensive needs
- cognitive processes
- socialisation
- in interaction with a specific situation
- different acts of terror can carry differences in psychological demands
  - extremely discriminate (e.g., assassination) to broadly indiscriminate (recall patterns of violence conceptual framework)

BUT: avoid stereotyping the terrorist or oversimplifying: No single motivation or personality can be valid for all circumstances

# Psychological (micro-level): normality (Crenshaw 1991)

“the outstanding common characteristic of terrorists is their  
**normality**”

The West German psychiatrist who conducted a pretrial examination of four members of the RAF concluded that they were “intelligent,” even “humorous,” and showed no symptoms of psychosis or neurosis and “no particular personality type.” (p390)

# Psychological (micro-level): difficulties (Crenshaw 1



studying individuals engaged in terrorism presents problems:

- **preconditions** change over time and **precipitants** are unpredictable
- interviewing terrorists: may discover **subsequent rationalisations** instead of prior attitudes/motivations

# Psychological (micro-level): endurance (Crenshaw 1981)

Within terrorist groups, individual/group dynamics of ...

- commitment,
- risk,
- solidarity,
- loyalty,
- guilt,
- revenge,
- isolation

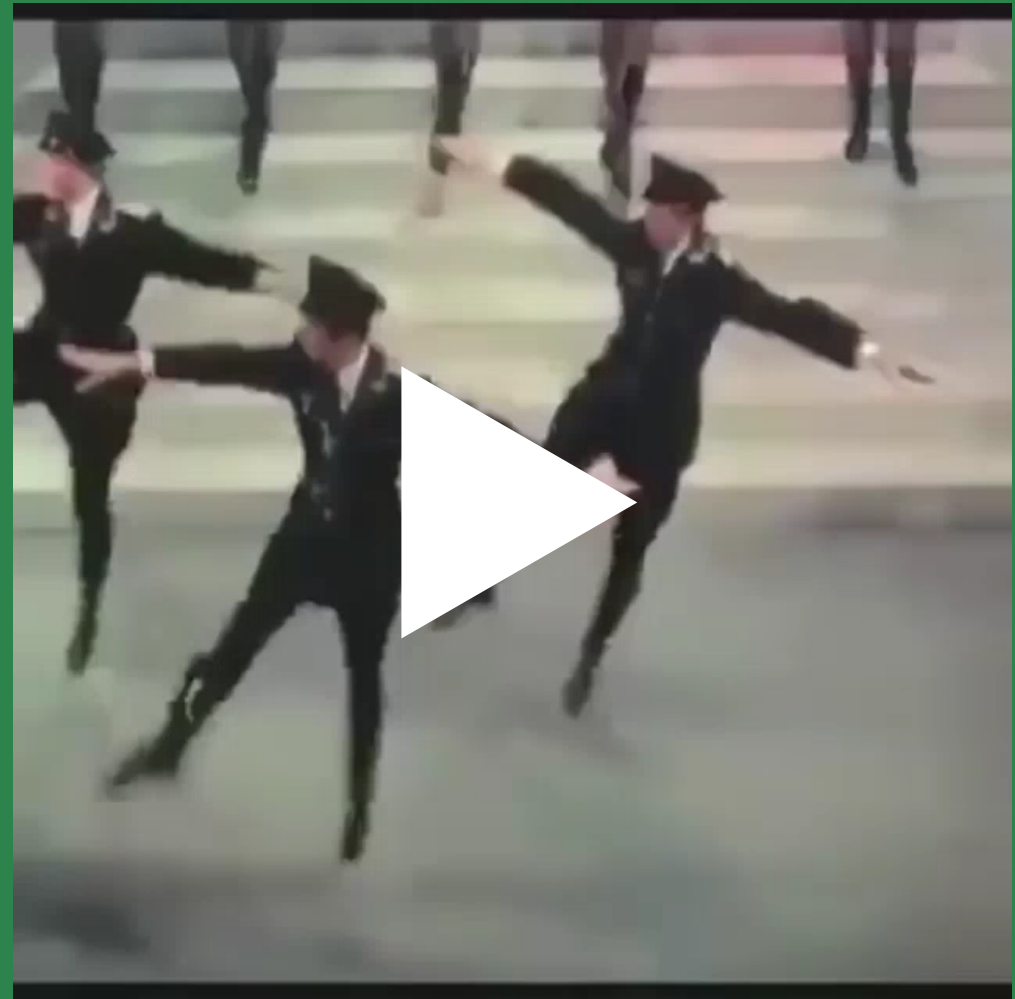
discourage a change in behaviour (and at the organisational level, strategy)—even when contextual conditions change.

# Politically violent groups connected to Germany

LMU

LUDWIG-  
MAXIMILIANS-  
UNIVERSITÄT  
MÜNCHEN

- roster of organisations
- discussion of causes





# (In)famous PV groups in or connected to Germany

“Those who only know one country, know no country” - Seymour Martin Lipset (inspired by Alexis de Tocqueville)

- well-known and covered in research literature
- diverse strategies, objectives, and ideological characteristics
- active in Germany and/or banned by Germany (or EU)

# (In)famous PV groups in or connected to Germany



*Antifaschistische Aktion* (Antifa, Germany and elsewhere),  
*Blood and Honour* (B&H, transnational),  
*Grey Wolves* (Turkey, but also transnational),  
*Hammerskins* (transnational),  
*Hezbollah* (Lebanon, but also transnational),  
*Hizb ut-Tahrir* (HT, transnational),  
*Islamic State* (IS, transnational),  
*Kommunistische Partei Deutschlands* ('Communist Party of Germany', KPD, Germany),  
*Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam* (LTTE, Sri Lanka),  
*Nationaldemokratische Partei Deutschlands* ('National Democratic Party of Germany', NPD, Germany),  
*National Socialist Underground* (NSU, Germany),  
*Partiya Karkerên Kurdistanê* ('Kurdistan Workers' Party', PKK,

Turkey, Syria and several other countries including Germany)

*Rote Armee Fraktion* ('Red Army Fraction,' RAF, Germany),

*Sozialistische Reichspartei* ('Socialist Reich Party,' SRP, Germany),

*Die Rechte* ('The Right', Germany)



- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: oppose fascist forces
- (common) Targets: political opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, property damage, doxxing



# Blood & Honour

- Territory of action:  
international (originally U.K.)
- Organisational structure:  
network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: white  
ethnostate
- (common) Targets: political and  
ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level  
violence, terrorism



# Grey Wolves

- Territory of action:  
international (originally Turkish)
- Organisational structure:  
hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: promote  
Turkish nationalism
- (common) Targets: political  
opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level  
violence



# Hammerskins

- Territory of action: international (originally U.S.)
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: white ethnostate
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, terrorism



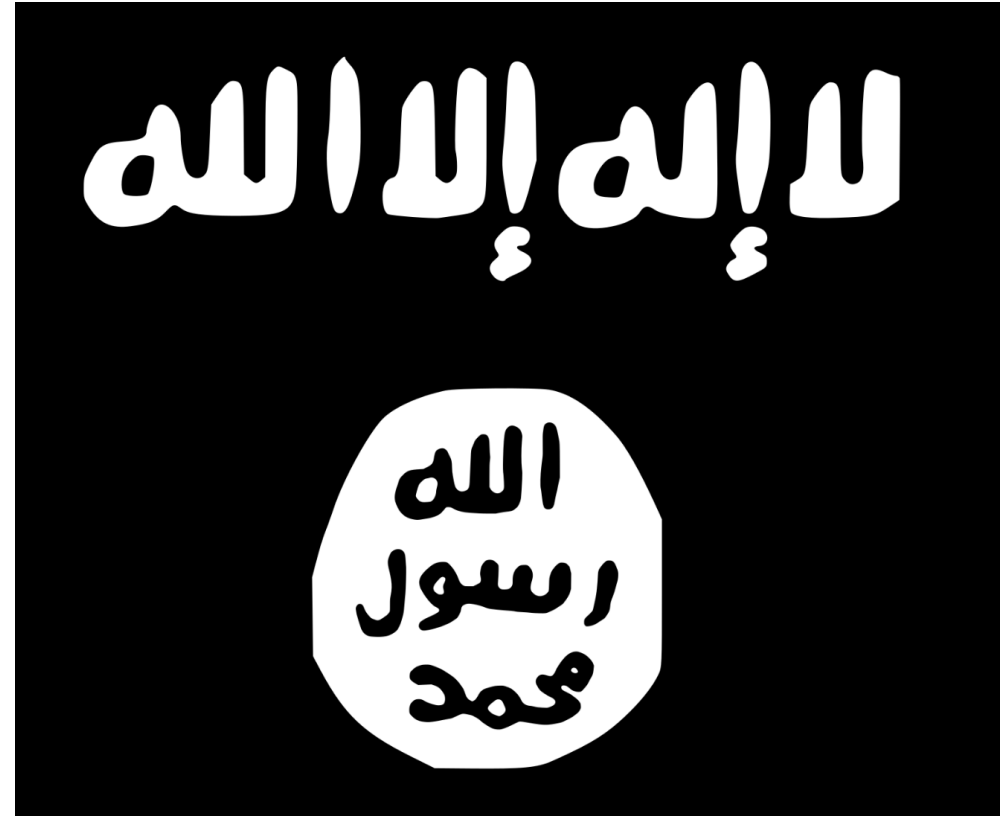
- Territory of action: Lebanon, but also transnational
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: Islamic state in Lebanon
- (common) Targets: Western forces, the power-sharing in Lebanon
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism



- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: united Islamic caliphate
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, incitement to violence, terrorism



- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: Islamic caliphate
- (common) Targets: political, ethnic, religious opponents
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism, militarised combat



# Kommunistische Partei Deutschlands (KPD)

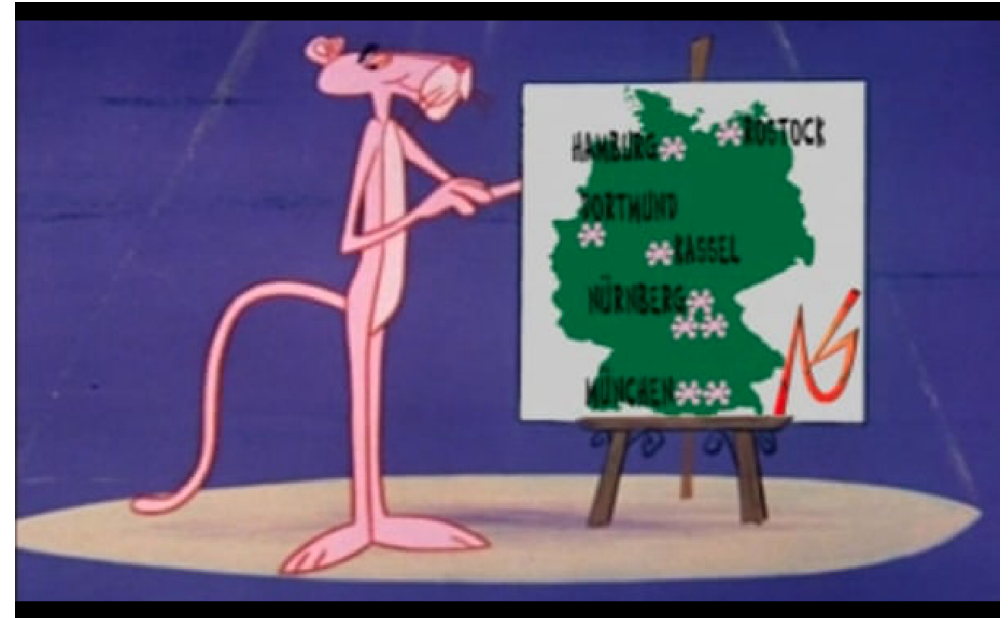
# Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam

- Territory of action: Sri Lanka, but also transnational
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: independent Tamil state
- (common) Targets: Sinhalese dominated Sri Lankan state
- Repertoire of actions: assassination, guerrilla activity



# National Socialist Underground

- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: small
- (main) Objective: terrorise non-ethnic Germans
- (common) Targets: non-ethnic Germans
- Repertoire of actions: murder, robbery



# Nationaldemokratische Partei Deutschlands (NPD)

- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: German ethno-state
- (common) Targets: political and ethnic opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, support for terrorism



# Partiya Karkeren Kurdistanê

- Territory of action: prominently Turkey, but international advocates
- Organisational structure:
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: Kurdish statehood
- (common) Targets: Turkish military and state
- Repertoire of actions: guerrilla activity



# Rote Armee Fraktion

- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: network
- Membership: small
- (main) Objective: revolutionary state
- (common) Targets: German state, right-wing figures
- Repertoire of actions: kidnapping, robbery, bombing, assassination



# Sozialistische Reichspartei (SRP)

- Territory of action: Germany
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: revive national socialist movement
- (common) Targets: political opponents
- Repertoire of actions: low-level violence, support for state violence

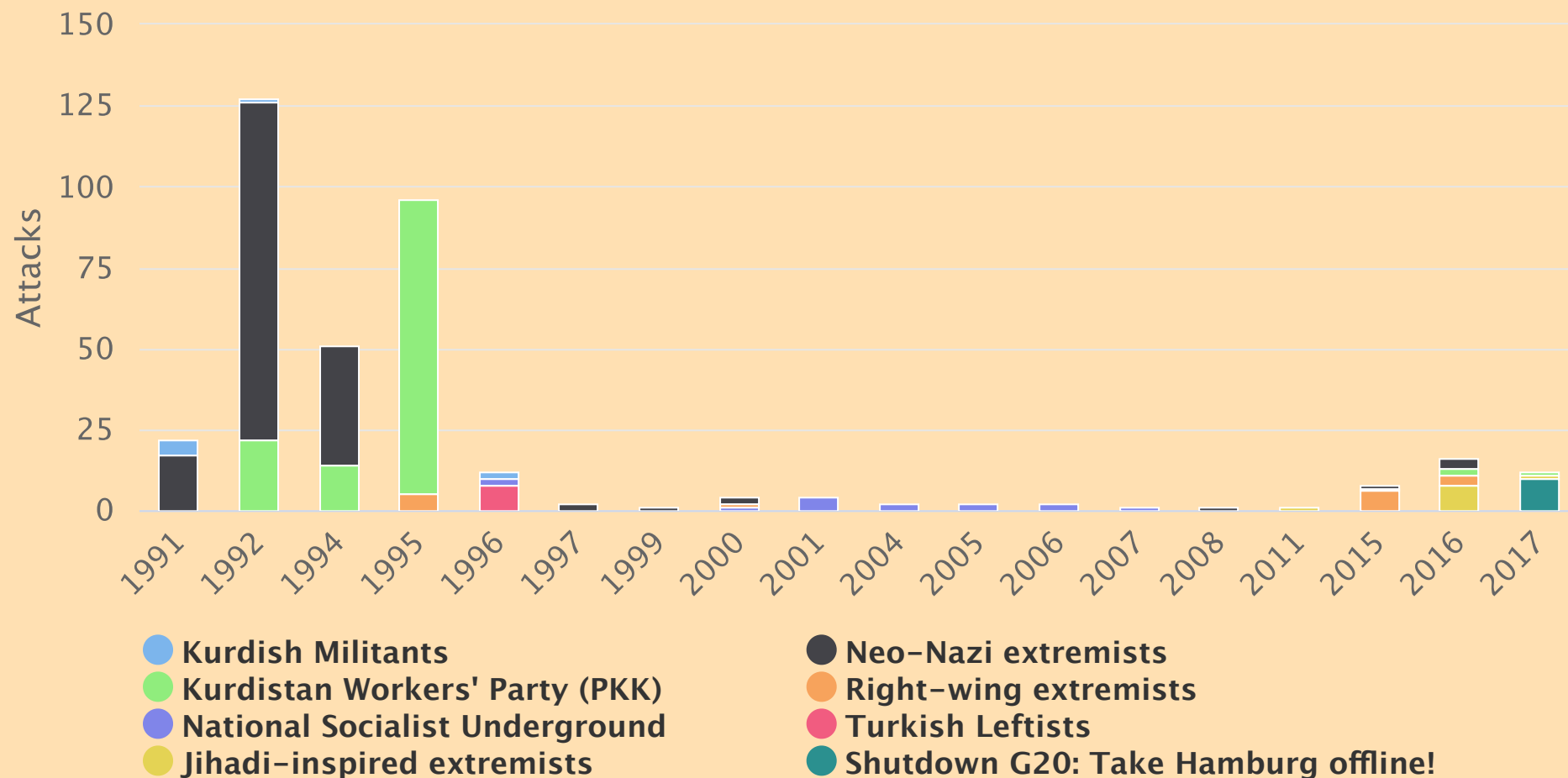


# Open data - Global Terrorism Data

Visualisation

Explanatory note

Data table



# Other PV groups that will crop up in readings

- Territory of action: international
- Organisational structure: (hierarchical) network
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: global Islamic caliphate
- (common) Targets: U.S. and Western institutions and societies
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism



# Brigate Rosse

- Territory of action: Italy
- Organisational structure:
- Membership: small
- (main) Objective: revolutionary state
- (common) Targets: Italian state institutions and NATO
- Repertoire of actions: robberies, kidnapping, low-level violence



# Euskadi Ta Askatasuna (ETA, 'Basque Homeland and

- Territory of action: Basque country
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: leftist revolution, independent state
- (common) Targets: state institutions
- Repertoire of actions: kidnapping, terrorism



# Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia

- Territory of action: Colombia
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: leftist revolution
- (common) Targets: state institutions, other paramilitaries
- Repertoire of actions: kidnapping, terrorism, drug trade



# Irish Republican Army

- Territory of action: British Isles
- Organisational structure: hierarchical
- Membership: large
- (main) Objective: united, independent Ireland
- (common) Targets: British military and institutions
- Repertoire of actions: terrorism



# Assigning groups for in-depth study



To get assigned a group to study in depth,  
scan the QR code or click this [LINK](#)  
You will be randomly assigned one of these groups:

- Antifa
- RAF - Rote Armee Fraktion
- IS - Islamic State
- alQaeda
- NPD/Heimat
- NSU - Nationalsozialistischer Untergrund
- PKK - Partiya Karkerên Kurdistanê

# Testing: determinants of right-wing terrorism in the U.S.

- Piazza (2017)
  - theorising and testing causes



# Piazza (2017) - testing causes

- Three groups of motivations (p. 54)
  - economic hardships and **grievances** (mechanism: drive resentment and support for terrorism)
  - greater inclusion and empowerment of women and racial minorities (mechanism: **perceived threat** to privilege)
  - resentment toward the U.S. political system and government (mechanism: necessitates ‘resistance against tyranny’)

Lays out differing theoretical/empirical contentions/findings about these motivations—and sets out to resolve them (theory-based and empirics-based **puzzles**) (**Day and Koivu 2019**)

# Piazza (2017) - research design

the study uses a cross-sectional panel time series design to examine the predictive quality of a series of state and national-level economic, social and political indicators on counts of domestic terrorist attacks launched by right-wing terrorist movements and individuals in the 50 US states for the period 1970–2011.

Let's break this down:

# Piazza (2017) - research design



the study uses a cross-sectional panel time series design to examine the predictive quality of a series of state and national-level economic, social and political indicators on counts of domestic terrorist attacks launched by right-wing terrorist movements and individuals in the 50 US states for the period 1970–2011

- ‘cross-sectional panel time series’ = different clusters of **analysis** over time
  - ‘in the 50 US states for the period 1970–2011’ = **state-year** is the unit of analysis (see Note 14)
- ‘predictive quality’ = research objective, *predict* (rather than ‘describe’ or ‘explain’), here meaning *inferential statistics*
- ‘series of state and national-level economic, social and political indicators’ = the (groups of) *independent variables* (IVs), corresponding to the 3 groups of motivations
- ‘counts of domestic terrorist attacks launched by right-wing terrorist movements and individuals’ = *dependent variable* (DV)

# Piazza (2017) - research design

| Variable group     | Indicators                              |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Economic grievance | Per cent in poverty                     |
|                    | Per cent employed in manufacturing      |
|                    | Number of individual farms in state     |
| Societal changes   | Rate of abortion                        |
|                    | Per cent of labour force that is female |
|                    | Change in non-white state population    |
| 'Big government'   | measure of Democrat party dominance     |
|                    | U.S. President a Democrat in given year |
|                    | Average income tax rate                 |

# Reading a regression table

Remember: regression is a tool for understanding a phenomenon as a linear function (generally)  $\rightarrow (y = mx + b)$

# Piazza (2017) - abridged regression table

|                                                 | [1] | [2]              | [3]                | [4]                | [5]                | [6]                |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----|------------------|--------------------|--------------------|--------------------|--------------------|
| <i>Percentage Below Poverty Line</i>            |     | 0.054<br>(0.034) |                    |                    | 0.026<br>(0.034)   | 0.012<br>(0.032)   |
| <i>Manufacturing Employment</i>                 |     | 3.751<br>(6.751) |                    |                    | 22.804<br>(18.584) | 30.732<br>(21.832) |
| <i>Change, No. of Individual Farms</i>          |     | 2.532<br>(1.953) |                    |                    | -1.427<br>(2.748)  | -0.226<br>(2.946)  |
| <i>Abortion Rate</i>                            |     |                  | 0.029**<br>(0.010) |                    | 0.026*<br>(0.012)  | 0.022†<br>(0.013)  |
| <i>Female Participation in Labor Force</i>      |     |                  | 0.102**<br>(0.033) |                    | 0.183†<br>(0.100)  | 0.209†<br>(0.125)  |
| <i>Growth of Non-white Pop (%)</i>              |     |                  | 0.026<br>(0.016)   |                    | 0.016<br>(0.020)   | 0.015<br>(0.016)   |
| <i>Democrat Control of<br/>State Government</i> |     |                  |                    | 0.055<br>(0.076)   | -0.010<br>(0.085)  | -0.043<br>(0.082)  |
| <i>US President Democrat</i>                    |     |                  |                    | 0.673**<br>(0.247) | 0.837**<br>(0.284) | 1.164**<br>(0.404) |
| <i>Federal Income Tax Rate</i>                  |     |                  |                    | 0.043<br>(0.138)   | -0.275<br>(0.232)  | -0.295<br>(0.313)  |

# Piazza (2017) - findings (interpretting reg. table)

- right-wing terrorism **not rooted in economic grievances, stress, or structural economic change**
- ‘gendered’ dimension to right-wing extremist activity: **where women are becoming more empowered, right-wing terrorism is more frequent**
  - predictors associated with women’s rights significantly boost the incidence of right-wing terrorism
  - *“On average, increases in state-level abortion rates or women’s participation in the workforce produce fewer than 0.05 more right-wing terrorist attacks per state per year.”*
- of ‘big gov.’ motivations, only the dummy variable for a Democrat U.S. President is significant
  - suggests **only peak-level and highly visible political predictors** are associated with increased incidence of right-wing terrorism

# Piazza (2017) - conclusions

1. economic factors are not reliable predictors of terrorist activity
2. social factors help drive right-wing terrorism. ('ills afflicting "traditional" American society')
3. partisan control over government matters at the national level, but not the state level, in determining right-wing terrorism

# Any feedback for this class?

Anonymous feedback here:

<https://forms.gle/NfF1pCfYMbkAT3WP6>

Alternatively, please send me an email: [m.zeller@lmu.de](mailto:m.zeller@lmu.de)

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**Questions about groups next meeting:** (1) Was radicalisation of members was motivated more by identity than by ideology? (2) Could individuals realistically have become radicalised without joining a social group connected to the organisation? (3) Was radicalisation into the group mostly *sudden* or *gradual*? (4) How did the group's narratives portray its members/community: victims, defenders, revolutionaries, religious warriors, other? (5) Did major political events accelerate radicalisation?

# References

- Crenshaw, Martha. 1981. "The Causes of Terrorism." *Comparative Politics* 13 (4): 379–99.
- Day, Christopher, and Kendra L. Koivu. 2019. "Finding the Question: A Puzzle-Based Approach to the Logic of Discovery." *Journal of Political Science Education* 15 (3): 377–86.  
<https://doi.org/10.1080/15512169.2018.1493594>.
- Piazza, James A. 2017. "The Determinants of Domestic Right-Wing Terrorism in the USA: Economic Grievance, Societal Change and Political Resentment." *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 34 (1): 52–80. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0738894215570429>.